Starting Dad's Baseline

Three things to write down first, and what can wait.

Dad's in his own place and handles most things himself. Nothing has gone wrong. You've started to wonder whether a few things take him longer than they used to, and there's nothing written down to check against.

Three things go on the page first, in the order below, at whatever pace suits you both.

1

What Dad does on his own, and the help he already has

Think back over his last ordinary week. Begin with what he does himself: washing and dressing, meals, the house, the shopping, his money and mail, his medicines, getting around. Beside each, add anything someone else does, however small. Put today's date at the top. [1]

WHY IT COMES HERE Every later page gets compared with this one, so it has to exist first. Beginning with what he does well keeps it a description of Dad and not a list of worries.

2

What has changed, if anything, in Dad's words and then the family's

Ask Dad what's as easy as ever, what takes longer than it used to, and where a hand is welcome. Then ask the one or two people who see him most. Write down each answer with whose it is and roughly when any change began. “Nothing I can think of” and “not sure when” are fine answers. [2]

WHY IT COMES HERE Slow change has no date unless someone gives it one, and Dad's own account is the part nobody else can supply.

3

What you'd like to ask a professional

Start a page of questions for his doctor, his pharmacist or your care consultant. Include this one: which changes would you want to hear about, and when would it make sense to look at things again? Keep questions about his medicines on a list of their own, and leave the medicines exactly as they are. [3]

WHY IT COMES HERE When Dad's situation should be reviewed is for the professionals who know his health to say. A written list means the question gets asked at an ordinary appointment.

What can wait

- Working out what any of it means. One dated page is a starting point, and nobody can read a trend from it.
- Filling every blank. “Not noted” is honest, and you can come back to it.
- Gathering his records and care instructions. Worth doing, and it can follow.
- Any decision about more help, services or where Dad lives. This step doesn't ask for one.
- What next year looks like. Nobody can write that down, and the page doesn't try.

What isn't for the page

The baseline is for ordinary weeks. If something about Dad's health concerns you today, that's a conversation with his doctor today, and an emergency is a call to emergency services.

What this guide doesn't do

It doesn't say how Dad is doing, predict anything, or decide when he should be assessed. It gets the first three things onto a dated page.

Ready for the next step?

You have a dated page of what Dad does on his own, a note of anything that has changed, and a list of questions. The care interview picks up where that page stops: it asks about each area of his daily life in turn, catches what a first page leaves out, and turns your answers into a Family Care Profile you can bring to any care conversation.

Create Your Free Family Care Profile ›

WHERE THIS COMES FROM

The everyday activities to note follow the lists the federal Administration for Community Living publishes. Starting with Dad's own account follows AARP's Prepare to Care guide. Writing questions down before a visit, and asking the doctor and the pharmacist before any medicine is adjusted, follow the Family Caregiver Alliance. The order is ours.

1. Administration for Community Living, What is Long-Term Care?
2. AARP, Prepare to Care: A Planning Guide for Families
3. Family Caregiver Alliance, Caregiver's Guide to Medications and Aging